

FLYING FORTRESS RAID

AT THE START OF THE WAR, US commanders believed that formations of B-17 Flying Fortresses would be immune to fighter attack, because of their speed, high altitude, and the weight of fire from their many guns. But German fighters were not easily deterred. They discovered that the best way to attack a B-17 was from straight ahead. The glass nose provided no protection and, until the chin gun was introduced in the B-17G, there was no forward-firing armament. Fighters attacking head-on sometimes shot a tail-gunner in the back with fire passing down the inside of the fuselage. Coming under fighter attack brought an intense experience of terror mixed with

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LIEUTENANT ROBERT MORRILL
B-17 PILOT

adrenaline-fueled excitement. Lieutenant Robert Morrill, a B-17 pilot in the raid on Regensburg, August 17, 1943, recalled: “Time after time my entire ship shook as every gun fired. The air was filled as the formation fired thousands upon thousands of tracers. I glanced behind me and found the top turret gunner standing in a heap of shell cases that covered the entire floor. In the cockpit my hands were glued to the wheel and throttles. I don’t believe I could have let go if I had tried. In spite of the cold, sweat was running from my hair under the helmet and down across the oxygen mask, falling on to my jacket and freezing there. But none of us ever thought of turning back.”

Fortunately the B-17 had a remarkable ability to survive punishment. Robust and reliable, many B-17s made it back to base even after receiving hits that took off large chunks of wing, fuselage, or tail. This was the key to its popularity with aircrews. As one American officer put it: “The B-17 was a very sturdy, easy-to-fly airplane that would take lots of damage and get you home.”



FLAK JACKET

To protect them from anti-aircraft fire, US aircrew wore reinforced flak jackets, which were introduced in 1942.

KEEPING OUT THE COLD

Like all the crew, the B-17 waist gunners wore heated flying suits to protect them from the cold at high altitudes. The temperature inside the aircraft could drop to -50°F (-45°C).



OFFICER PILOTS

The pilot and copilot of a USAAF bomber were always officers, and usually college graduates. The B-17 afforded them an excellent view of the sky and ground.

